The human species

BACKGROUND

mammals (say 'ma-mels') – warm-blooded animals with backbones that feed their young with milk

Humans are an important part of the biodiversity of ecosystems.

Human reproduction

Humans reproduce in the same way as other mammals. After sexual intercourse, a single **sperm cell** fertilises the female's **ovum** (egg). Usually, one egg is released from the female's ovaries every month. If the male sperm cell reaches the egg at just the right time, the sperm goes into the egg and the two cells join together and begin multiplying. The cells continue to grow for nine months inside the female's womb. The human baby is born after passing through the female's vagina (birth canal).

☞ **1** Underline the correct word within the brackets to complete these sentences.

a) Human reproduction is (similar / different) to the way other mammals reproduce.

b) A (male / female) sperm cell fertilises the egg of a (male / female).

c) The physical activity that enables the egg and the sperm to come into contact is called sexual (intercourse / joining).

d) An egg has been fertilised if a (sperm cell / ovum) has gone into it.

e) The multiplying cells eventually become an (embryo / womb).

f) The baby travels through the (ovaries / vagina) during birth.

2 Complete the table by adding the missing letters.

Singular noun	Plural noun	Adjective
cell	__ __ __ __ __	__ __ __ __ ular
female	__ __ __ __ __ __ __	__ __ __ __ __ __
mammal	__ __ __ __ __ __ __	__ __ __ __ __ __ ian
sex	__ __ __ es	__ __ __ ual
ovary	__ __ __ __ __ __ __	__ __ __ __ ian
embryo	__ __ __ __ __ __ __	__ __ __ __ __ __nic

ISBN 978 1 92571 064 9
© Ally Chumley and Blake Education 2014

The human species CONT'D

Human babies

Just like young mammals, human babies have special needs that they look to their parents to provide. They include the same things that other mammals need – food, water, shelter, warmth and safety. Human babies also have emotional and social needs. Humans usually make a home for their young where they can be kept safe and where they feel part of a family or community group.

3 List the similarities between human offspring and the offspring of other mammals.

4 List the differences between human offspring and the offspring of some other mammal species.

Human adaptations

Most scientists believe that humans have changed over millions of years. **Adaptation** is the name given to describe the way that living things change and become better suited to their habitats. For example, human skin tones and hair colour have adapted to suit living in different climates.

Like other animals, humans are still changing. These changes are very tiny, but they will be very obvious over thousands or millions of years.

5 Fill in the vowels to complete this sentence.

H __ m __ ns b __ l __ ng to a sp __ c __ __s called *Homo sapiens*.

6 What features do you think will help the human species survive the next 10 000 years? List each feature in your workbook, and explain why you think it will be important. Then draw a picture of your new human species.

© Ally Chumley and Blake Education 2014
ISBN 978 1 92571 064 9